

FUNERALS & COMMUNITY TRADITIONS

“When one person leaves, a community gathers.”

Birth begins a life within a family. Death closes one chapter, but it does not immediately end the relationships surrounding that person. For the family, there is grief. For the community, there is responsibility. For those who knew the deceased, there is memory. And for a society shaped by kinship and community relationships, death can become a moment when people come together to support those who remain. Among Muslim Pashtun communities, funeral life exists at the intersection of Islamic practice, local custom, family tradition and changing social realities. There is therefore no single funeral ceremony that represents every Orakzai family.

COMMUNAL FAREWELL

“The collective responsibility of the tribe”



“A community coming together in the landscape of remembrance.”

DEATH AS A LIFE-CYCLE EVENT

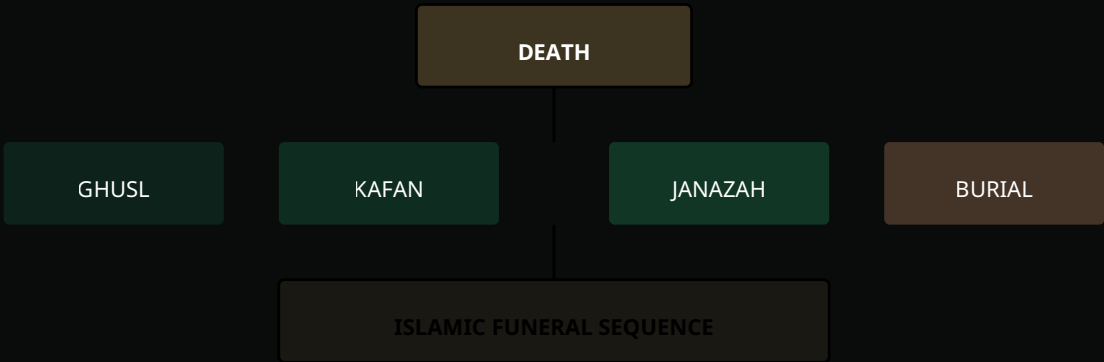
Death is understood as another major life-cycle transition, marking the end of a physical presence but the beginning of a collective memory. In Orakzai society, this transition reinforces the person's place within the family, the kinship network, and the wider community.

BIRTH → LIFE → FAMILY → COMMUNITY → DEATH & MEMORY

“The completion of the social life-cycle.”

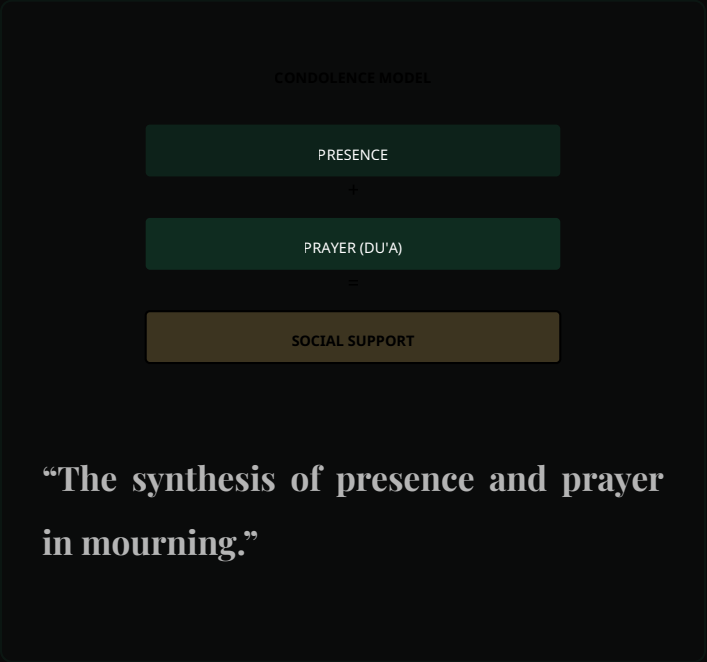
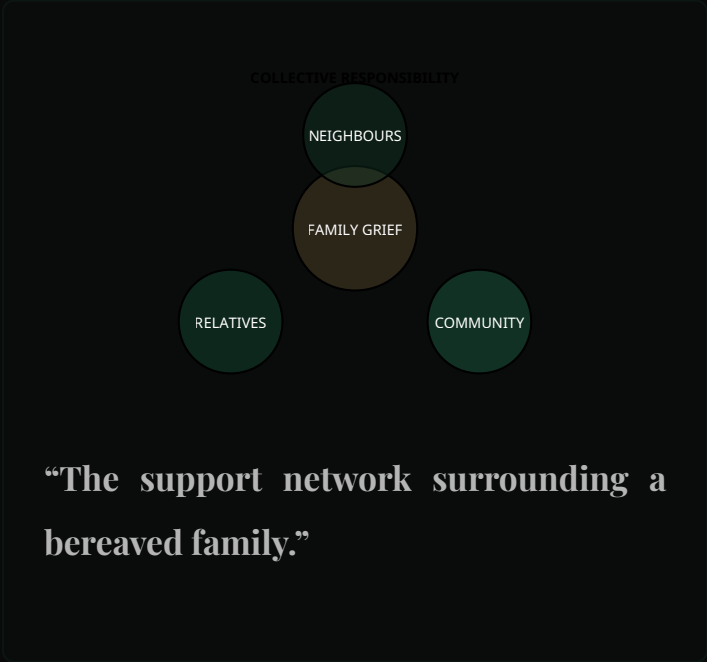
ISLAMIC FUNERAL FRAMEWORK

The core sequence of an Islamic funeral is universally recognized across Pashtun communities. This includes the ritual washing (Ghusl), the white burial shroud (Kafan), the funeral prayer (Janazah), and the burial itself. These religious requirements emphasize the equality of all human beings in death.⁴



“The essential religious framework for farewell.”

In Orakzai tribal society, a death triggers a collective response. Neighbours and relatives often take over the daily responsibilities of the bereaved family—such as providing food and welcoming guests—to allow the family space for grief. This communal support system is a core pillar of Pashtun social life.¹⁵



PRACTICE	ORAKZAI-SPECIFIC	PASHTUN-WIDE	ISLAMIC	REGIONAL	EVIDENCE
Janazah Prayer	Common Practice	Standard	Mandatory	Universal	Aadil & Shahzaib (2024) [4]
Community Support	Documented ORAKZAI	Core Value	Encouraged	Standard	Ahmed (1980) [1]
Hujra Role	Documented PASHTUN	Core Institution	-	Regional	Historical Records [5]
Ancestral Graveyards	Documented REGIONAL	Common	-	Regional	Historical Records [5]
Sectarian Context	Shia Traditions ORAKZAI	Localized	-	Kurram/ Orakzai	Akbar (2013) [3]

Urbanization and migration have significantly altered funeral practices. Families in cities like Peshawar or Islamabad often adapt to formal cemetery systems and hospital protocols. Digital technology, such as WhatsApp and memorial pages, now plays a role in public announcements and preserving family history. However, the core values of dignity, privacy, and community support remain central.²⁵

TRADITION VS. MODERNITY

ANCESTRAL HOMELAND

URBAN / DIASPORA

"Adapting rites to new legal and social systems"

“The geographic and social shift in funeral practices.”

DIGITAL MEMORY ARCHIVE

PHOTOGRAPHS / DOCUMENTS

ORAL HISTORY RECORDINGS

FAMILY ARCHIVE

“The role of technology in preserving ancestral memory.”

THE LIMITS OF TRADITION: Not every funeral practice is an Islamic requirement, nor is every Pashtun custom uniquely Orakzai. Furthermore, not every family practices tradition in the same way. It is essential to respect the diversity of religious interpretation and family preference.

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

Death teaches us something that ordinary days can hide. We discover who comes when a family needs support. Who remembers the name of the deceased. Who carries the responsibility. Who tells the stories. And who remains after the gathering has ended. For me, the importance of funeral traditions is not in preserving every custom exactly as it once existed. It is in understanding what those customs tell us about people. A prayer. A grave. A family gathering. An elder remembering a life. A neighbour arriving without being asked. These moments reveal that identity is not only about where we come from. It is also about how we stand beside one another when someone is gone.

